

Elephants and relatives

The three living species of elephant are the largest land animals today. But elephants weren't always so huge. The earliest known species was just 2 ft (60 cm) tall—the size of a cat. Over time they grew larger and their trunks and tusks grew longer, giving rise to an extraordinary range of giant mammals.

Deinotherium

DIE-no-THEER-ee-um



- **When** 10 million to 10,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe, Africa, Asia
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Height** 16 ft (5 m) tall at the shoulder
- **Diet** Plants

The third largest land mammal that ever lived, *Deinotherium* was slightly larger than a modern African elephant. Its trunk was much shorter than a modern elephant's, and it had backward-curving tusks that grew from the lower jaw. It might have used the tusks to dig up roots, strip bark, or pull down branches to reach the leaves.



Large skull

Curved tusks
growing from
the lower jaw



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Almost all early elephants had trunks
- Mostly naked, wrinkled skin
- Most had tusks
- Columnlike legs

When

The first elephants appeared in the Paleogene Period (about 40 million years ago).

